Treasure in Clay Jars

In hard times God's power shows through our weakness, and we do not lose heart because we look to what is unseen and eternal.

Main passage	2 Corinthians 4:7-18 (KJV)
Topic	Afflictions and Adversities
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: God puts his treasure in clay jars	7 min
Teaching point 2: Pressed, but not crushed	7 min
Teaching point 3: Look at what is unseen and eternal	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Hold up (or describe) a plain clay flowerpot. Ask: "Would anyone keep diamonds in this?" Probably not; we put treasure in strong boxes. Yet Paul says God has put the greatest treasure in the world in fragile clay containers: us. Today's lesson is for anyone who feels cracked, tired or under pressure.

Teacher note: Some in the class may be grieving or ill. Allow space for honesty; this lesson is not about pretending suffering is small, but about where hope is found in it.

Scripture (3 min)

2 Corinthians 4:7-18

[7] But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us. [8] We are troubled on every side, yet not distressed; we are perplexed, but not in despair; [9] Persecuted, but not forsaken; cast down, but not destroyed; [10] Always bearing about in the body the dying of the Lord Jesus, that the life also of Jesus might be made manifest in our body. [11] For we which live are alway

delivered unto death for Jesus' sake, that the life also of Jesus might be made manifest in our mortal flesh. [12] So then death worketh in us, but life in you. [13] We having the same spirit of faith, according as it is written, I believed, and therefore have I spoken; we also believe, and therefore speak; [14] Knowing that he which raised up the Lord Jesus shall raise up us also by Jesus, and shall present us with you. [15] For all things are for your sakes, that the abundant grace might through the thanksgiving of many redound to the glory of God. [16] For which cause we faint not; but though our outward man perish, yet the inward man is renewed day by day. [17] For our light affliction, which is but for a moment, worketh for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory; [18] While we look not at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen: for the things which are seen are temporal; but the things which are not seen are eternal.

Read the passage aloud. Pause after verses 8-9 and let the four "yet not" contrasts sink in.

Background (5 min)

Second Corinthians is Paul's most personal letter. Some in Corinth looked down on him: he was not impressive to look at, he suffered constantly, and his life did not look like success. In chapters 4-6 Paul answers that his weakness is the very place where God's power is seen.

Paul had faced beatings, imprisonments, shipwreck, hunger and danger (11:23-28). He is not speaking from a comfortable chair when he calls his troubles "light affliction" (v. 17). He is weighing them against eternity.

Teaching point 1: God puts his treasure in clay jars (7 min)

The treasure is the gospel: "the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ" (v. 6). The container is ordinary, breakable people. God does this on purpose, so that it is plain the power is his and not ours. Our weakness is not a barrier to God's work. It is the stage on which his power is shown.

Supporting verses

2 Corinthians 4:6-7: For God, who commanded the light to shine out of darkness, hath shined in our hearts, to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ. But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us.

2 Corinthians 12:9-10: And he said unto me, My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness. Most gladly therefore will I rather glory in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me. Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities, in reproaches, in necessities, in persecutions, in distresses for Christ's sake: for when I am weak, then am I strong.

1 Corinthians 1:27: But God hath chosen the foolish things of the world to confound the wise; and God hath chosen the weak things of the world to confound the things which are mighty;

> *"signifies, more literally, vessels made of shells, which are very brittle"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 2 Corinthians 4:7

Handout blanks (answers)

We have this treasure in **earthen** vessels.

Our weakness shows that the power is of **God**.

Teaching point 2: Pressed, but not crushed (7 min)

Paul lists four hardships, and each one has a "but not": troubled but not distressed, perplexed but not in despair, persecuted but not forsaken, cast down but not destroyed. Christians are not spared trouble. But trouble never has the last word, because God never leaves us. Jesus was truly forsaken on the cross so that his people never will be.

Supporting verses

2 Corinthians 4:8-12 (read from the Bible)

Hebrews 13:5: Let your conversation be without covetousness; and be content with such things as ye have: for he hath said, I will never leave thee, nor forsake thee.

Psalm 34:19: Many are the afflictions of the righteous: but the LORD delivereth him out of them all.

> *"Whatever condition the children of God may be in, in this world, they have a "but not" to comfort themselves with"*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on 2 Corinthians 4:8-18

> *"Jesus was forsaken by both; so much do His sufferings exceed those of His people"*
> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on 2 Corinthians 4:9

Handout blanks (answers)

Persecuted, but not **forsaken**.

Cast down, but not **destroyed**.

Teaching point 3: Look at what is unseen and eternal (7 min)

"For which cause we faint not" (v. 16). Our bodies wear out, but inwardly we are renewed day by day. Paul calls his sufferings light and momentary when set beside an "eternal weight of glory." The key is where we fix our eyes. We look past what is seen and temporary to what is unseen and eternal, above all the resurrection (v. 14).

Supporting verses

2 Corinthians 4:14-18 (read from the Bible)

Romans 8:18: For I reckon that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory which shall be revealed in us.

1 Peter 1:6-7: Wherein ye greatly rejoice, though now for a season, if need be, ye are in heaviness through manifold temptations: That the trial of your faith, being much more precious than of gold that perisheth, though it be tried with fire, might be found unto praise and honour and glory at the appearing of Jesus Christ:

> *"It was the assured hope of the resurrection which sustained them in all their trials."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 2 Corinthians 4:14

> *"While we aim not at the things which are seen; do not make them our object; are not striving to obtain them"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 2 Corinthians 4:18

Handout blanks (answers)

Though our outward man perish, the inward man is **renewed** day by day.

The things which are not seen are **eternal**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why would God choose to put his treasure in fragile people instead of impressive ones?

So that the power is clearly his; our weakness points away from us to him.

2. Which of the four "but not" phrases in verses 8-9 speaks most to you, and why?

Answers will vary.

3. Paul calls his afflictions "light" and "but for a moment." How can he say that, given what he suffered?

He weighs them against eternal glory; compared with eternity, even great suffering is brief.

4. What practical things help you "look at the things which are not seen" when life is hard?

Scripture, prayer, worship with others, remembering the resurrection, encouragement from fellow believers.

Application (3 min)

Memorize 2 Corinthians 4:16-18 this week. When a trouble presses on you, say the "but not" out loud: "Pressed, but not crushed." Reach out to one person in the church who is going through a hard time, and share this passage with them.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord, we are clay jars, cracked and weak. Thank you for the treasure of the gospel you have placed in us. When we are pressed, keep us from being crushed; when we are cast down, keep us from despair. Renew us inwardly day by day, and fix our eyes on what is unseen and eternal, until we see you face to face. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 2 Corinthians 4:7

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on 2 Corinthians 4:8-18

Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on 2 Corinthians 4:9

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 2 Corinthians 4:14

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 2 Corinthians 4:18

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